

God rewards struggle.

The life of CONON, a presbyter of the monastery of Penthucula.

"A Little Bit"

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The Orthodox Christian faith is full of life-giving truth, but it is also very complex and even overwhelming to beginners. It is not at all like the typical Western expression of Christianity, and this is part of the reason why it is so overwhelming and seems too big to many people. These small postings are in attempt to give **"A Little Bit"** of knowledge and edification regarding Orthodox Christianity. Since they come from my mind, they are not necessarily organized, but they are absolutely from the heart. It may be very hard to learn all the fasting rules and to go to long services and to read the Fathers, or even the Bible, but it is not so hard to read or listen to or watch a short video about something that is just **"A Little Bit"** about Christianity. Please send suggestions for other topics, and comments. [Priest Seraphim Holland](mailto:seraphim@orthodox.net), (seraphim@orthodox.net) who is learning a little bit each day about how to be a real Christian.

When we visited Abba Athanasius in the monastery of our holy father Saba he told us of an Alexandrian presbyter called Conon who was in charge of Baptisms. The fathers had decreed that the high quality of his character made him worthy of baptizing those who came seeking for it. So, he anointed with the holy Chrism and baptized those who came. But whenever he had to anoint a woman he became so agitated that he wanted to leave the monastery. While battling with this thought the holy John Baptist appeared to him, saying: "Endure, and persevere and I will lift this burden from you."

One day an attractive young Persian woman came to be baptized who was so beautiful that the presbyter could not bring himself to anoint her bare flesh with oil. When Archbishop Peter heard that the girl had already been there two days he was exceedingly angry with the old man, and even wanted to delegate this ministry to a deaconess but refrained from doing so as he did not want to be seen to be doing anything contrary to the canons. But Conon the presbyter took his cloak and went, saying that he would not remain any longer in that place. He had got as far as the hills, when behold, the holy John Baptist met him in the way and spoke to him gently, saying: "Go back to your monastery and I will lift this battle from you."

"I certainly will not go back," replied Abba Conon indignantly. "You have so often made these promises and not fulfilled them."

Then the holy John made him sit down and take off his clothes. He made the sign of the cross three times on his navel and said: "Believe me, presbyter Conon, I had been hoping that you would have been able to receive a reward because of this battle. As it is, however, look, I have taken this battle away from you, but you have forfeited any reward."

The presbyter returned to the coenobium, to take up once more his baptismal ministry. The next day he anointed and baptized the young woman, hardly even noticing that she was, in fact, a woman. He continued the ministry of baptism for another twelve years in such tranquility of mind and body that he never experienced any excitement of the flesh, nor consciously thought of anyone specifically as a woman. And so, in peace he lived out his days. (From: <http://www.vitae-patrum.org.uk/page141.html>)

This story is very instructive for us. I have known people that want to run away from situations where they feel that they have trouble with uncleanness. But that does not mean that we can quit a job and be without work, just because there might be someone who says unclean things in the job or perhaps there are unclean posters in various places in the job. Of course, there are places that we should flee from – I would not recommend that an alcoholic work in a bar or a person with impurity live near a whorehouse, but we are called

to struggle against our sexual passions and all other passions. Many times, it is not pleasing to God that we decide to struggle against our passion by running away from something.

I have a funny story, or at least it is to me, regarding impure pictures at work. A long time ago in a galaxy far away I was a computer programmer, and I worked contracts. One of the contracts was at Anheuser-Busch. Everybody in their cubicles had all the beer posters up, and there was an endless supply of them. You know the posters I'm referring to, with all of the buxom women in bikinis and such. I didn't have anything on my walls because I wasn't about to put that stuff up. People around me didn't like that, so they put "beer girls" up for me. I took them down, and they put them back up. So, I went to the store and bought big posters of lions and tigers. Once I put those up, they never bothered me again.

Another story from that era. Sometimes in offices people just stand around and talk for a little while and they should be working. I did that too, but I would always leave the group whenever they started to tell dirty jokes. I didn't say anything, I just walked away and went back to my desk. I think I developed a little bit of a reputation, and they must've decided they wanted to do something to embarrass me. We would go to lunch, usually once a week, together. One week they decided they were going to go to "Hooters". Now this is before the Internet was popular, and I didn't know what "Hooters" was. I literally thought that it was a restaurant that had a picture of an owl as its mascot. It's not that I didn't know that their title was actually a slang word, but it never occurred to me that the restaurant had anything to do with anything except a picture of an owl. We were getting ready to go, and I saw everybody in acting conspiratorial and I thought something's not right. So, I begged off and said I had work to do. Later on, I found out what "Hooters" really was. I've never been in one of those kinds of restaurants and I never plan to be.

We win our salvation, by struggle, with grace helping us. Do not measure your life by how close you are to perfection, but rather by how much you struggle and depend on God to help you. If you struggle, the events that you perceive as failure, when seasoned with repentance, will attract grace, and you will eventually be completely victorious. This story, above from the life of Conan the presbyter, shows us that God will reward struggle (with failure mixed in too! – Because by definition if we struggle we will sometimes fail) and without struggle we cannot win a crown.

Tags: A Little bit, Sexual temptation, Struggle, Stories, Priest Seraphim Holland

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